THE ADVENT OF THE BHARATIYA JANA SANGH AND DEEN DAYAL UPADHYAYA

It took a while to happen. While Savarkar and Golwalkar had attracted a lot of attention with their ideas in the 1920s and 1930s, the only political party willing to take them seriously was the Akhil Bharatiya Hindu Mahasabha, a fringe movement of which Savarkar became president in 1937. The Hindu Mahasabha fancied itself as a sort of Hindu answer to the Muslim League, but never enjoyed even a fraction of its support; indeed, the overwhelming majority of Hindu voters backed the secular Indian National Congress Party, rather than the party that claimed to be acting in the name of India's Hindus. The Mahasabha, however, openly advocated both 'Hindutva' and 'Hindu Rashtra', even as the Muslim League's call for Partition was tearing the country apart on communal lines. The Mahasabha's best-known leader, Syama Prasad Mookerjee, its president in 1944, was conscious of the limitations of Hindu nationalism as a political platform in such circumstances, and called for the membership of Hindu Mahasabha to be thrown open to all communities. Not surprisingly—since this would have vitiated the communal logic of the Mahasabha itself—his own members spurned his call, prompting Mookerjee to resign and to form a new political party in collaboration with the RSS. This was the Bharatiya Jana Sangh.

Mookerjee's choice of name for his new party was instructive. 'Bharatiya' literally meant 'Indian', 'Jana' the people, and 'Sangh,' in a genuflection to the RSS, which liked to refer to itself as 'the Sangh', stood for 'organisation'. Thus the Bharatiya Jana Sangh was the Indian People's Organisation. The Jana Sangh was openly viewed as a political emanation of the RSS, which had been banned after Mahatma Gandhi's assassination in 1948 and only allowed to resume functioning as a purely social and cultural, rather than political, association. The RSS could continue to advocate Hindu Samaj (Hindu society) but not a Hindu Rashtra—that would be a political objective which only a political party could pursue. And so a political party was born. The Bharatiya Jana Sangh was linked to the RSS, it was said, by an umbilical cord; its establishment of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh gave the RSS a political arm that would pursue Hindu interests within a national, as opposed to